VERBAL

Reading Comprehension

Inference, Title & Tone

Assignment 2

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PASSAGE - A

Few realize that only a very small portion of the country's agricultural production depends on electrically operated pump-sets. Several studies have indicated that the benefits from free or subsidized electricity went to the richer section of the farmers. In water scarce regions of Gujarat, rich farmers running tube wells on subsidized electricity, were selling water to poor farmers at high prices. Similar incidents are reported from other states also. Depletion of ground water due to excessive pumping where power is free is another common complaint. As mentioned earlier, the poorest of poor in rural and urban areas are still not connected to the electricity grid. Those are the classes of society which deserve state resources for their uplifting. Hence subsidizing electricity might not be the ideal vehicle to bring about social justice or boost agricultural production. Agriculture no doubt deserves special considerations and subsidies but free electricity may not be the most appropriate means. These issues need exhaustive studies before policy decisions are taken in haste by central and state governments. Unless the financial health of the SEBs improves, no reform programme can improve their performance. Let us hope that the revised bill will address this issue.

1. It can be inferred from the passage that

1. State governments are instrumental in depletion of ground water by subsidizing electricity for farmers.
2. The author is not optimistic that the lacunae in the Electricity Bill will be removed by suitable amendments.
3. The problem of irrigation can be solved by connecting the poorest of the poor to the grid.
4. SEB's by not improving their performance are responsible for inadequate policy responses.
5. Combining subsidies and agriculture may not be a good idea.

2. Subsidizing electricity for agriculture is not the ideal vehicle for bringing about social justice because

1. Rich farmers tend to exploit poor farmers by selling water at very high rates.
2. Only a small portion of our agriculture depends on electrically operated pump sets and the poorest farmers are not connected to the grid.
3. The financial health of the SEB's cannot improve if subsidies exist.
4. Depletion of ground water by excessive pumping will hamper future use of pump sets for irrigation.
5. This is only a stop-gap measure.

PASSAGE - B

When a budget is presented at the beginning of a financial year, analysts get busy evaluating its rationale, its possible impact, the gains and losses accruing from it for different sections. We now have a new addition to this convention, namely 'gender budgeting'– a rather mystifying term that indicates exercises to highlight how women have fared in the national, state or local budget.

What does gender have to do with public finance? Plenty, as we will see the burden of paying for budgetary expenditure is largely borne by the people in the country and in return, they are the ones who get benefited by various schemes and projects that the budget launches. Makers of public policies determine the nature of these actions and the particular groups that are to benefit from them. They also determine the means used to finance those state activities and also how the burden of the necessary levies is shared between different groups of citizens. All these decisions have some positive or negative impact on different sections of the society; and given the nature of gender construction in each society, this impact is unlikely to be uniform between men and women. For example, poor parents in India are often reluctant to spend as much on the medication for their daughters as they are for their sons. Therefore, schemes for free health care for children may benefit girls more than boys, who in any case, have received the necessary care from private sources. On the taxation side,

because Indian women work mostly in the informal sector, they are seldom liable to pay income taxes. But, because they are more prone to be poor, they are likely to be worse hit by subsidies in the public distribution of food grains.

Gender budgeting exercises are set against the background of such gender-based differences that are built into the social and economic fabric of each society. They attempt to assess how far these prevailing biases are incorporated in budgetary measures and whether there are any attempts being made by the state to correct for them. The intention behind these exercises is by no means to ask for a separate and exclusive budget or policy plan oriented only to gender related issues. Rather, it is to highlight the biases that are inherent in the mainstream budget and to suggest ways to change the overall outlook of all government policies towards the promotion of true equality between the genders. The operative term has to be equality, that is to say, true parity between the capabilities of the two genders to operate in the economy and the society, notwithstanding inherent biological differences. This point needs particular stress in this context. Too often women are fobbed off with public schemes that are supposed to be good for them but which do nothing to change their basic position, at home or outside. Over the past few decades, policy makers have repeatedly declared their intentions to use the state machinery for promoting women's empowerment; gender budgeting exercises are meant to verify, from actual schemes and allotments included in the budget how far these intentions are actually being translated into concrete policies.

3. The main purpose of gender budgeting exercises is

1. To create a separate budget or policy plan to address gender related issues
2. To verify how far actual schemes and allotments included in the budget meet the intentions to use state machinery for promoting women's empowerment
3. To attain true parity between the capabilities of the two genders to operate in the economy and society
4. All of the above.
5. None of the above.

4. Which of the following can be described as a measure conforming to gender budgeting?

1. The government reserves 15% of the seats in IITs for girl students.
2. The government provides for free education of girls up to the postgraduate level
3. The government announces a special festival release of sugar from the PDS for women
4. RBI allows banks to increase lending to SHG's working with women
5. Women's reservation bill in the legislature.

PASSAGE - C

If you look at photographs of our politicians, or catch their video clips, you will find that their mouths are always open. That's because it's a politician's reflex action to speak at the sight of a mike, a camera or an audience, even if it's an audience of one. The Open Mouth Syndrome is such that it's accompanied by a complete absence of thought. Why else would politicians froth at the mouth and want stringent action against soft drink manufacturers and not say a word about the ground realities of our water supply?

Those ground realities are appalling, to say the least. India may be shining for you and me, but 60 percent of our countrymen do not have running water in their homes, and as many as 30 percent of households have to trudge long distances to get water from a common community source. The worst statistic, though, is this: One million children do not reach the age of five because they die of water-borne diseases.

Commonsense tells us that if soft drinks are contaminated, it's because of the quality of water available in the country. After all, soft drink manufacturers could not be adding contaminants deliberately; nor could they be adding pesticides to improve the taste of their drinks; Common sense further tells us that the bad quality of water would contaminate most food produce: vegetables and fruit, not only because they grow in the same

earth as ground water, but because they are also continuously sprayed by pesticides. Animal feed, too, is affected, so milk as well as meats would necessarily be contaminated.

Would we consume more vegetables, meats, dairy products and meats than colas? Obviously, yes. Has anyone done a study of contaminants in our daily food basket? If not, are the colas being attacked because they are a soft target? Would someone tell us how many bottles of Coke we need to consume per day for it to be harmful? After all, the measure for contaminants is parts per billion. That seems like an awfully small quantity, so one needs to know whether one bottle per day is harmful. Or ten. Or hundred.

Whatever the figure, what the cola furore has achieved is to divert the debate from two very real issues. The first, already mentioned, is the abysmal quality and distribution of water, which in the 21st century and 60 years after independence, is a disgrace. The second is a national policy on pesticide/fungicide usage, defined limits of permissible contaminants, and how to enforce the standards once they are formulated.

5. Which of the following represents the central idea of the passage?

1. Soft drinks are not very harmful compared to other food products.
2. There should be a policy that defines permissible contaminants in food and enforces standards.
3. The pesticides in colas debate have diverted attention from real issues of contamination in food articles.
4. We use too many pesticides in growing food produce.

6. Which of the following can be inferred from the passage?

1. There is no talk about contamination in water because it affects only the poor.
2. Politicians love to talk, even when there is no need to.
3. Soft drinks are contaminated because the quality of water is not good
4. We do not know what level of contaminants in food is actually unsafe.

PASSAGE - D

Would you be happier if you were richer? Many people believe that they would be. But research conducted over many years suggests that greater wealth implies greater happiness only at quite low levels of income. People in the United States, for example, are, on average, richer than New Zealanders, but they are not happier. More dramatically, people in Austria, France, Japan, and Germany appear to be no happier than people in much poorer countries, like Brazil, Colombia, and the Philippines.

Comparisons between countries with different cultures are difficult, but the same effect appears within countries, except at very low-income levels, such as below $12,000 annually for the US. Beyond that point, an increase in income doesn't make a lot of difference to people's happiness. Americans are richer than they were in the 1950s, but they are not happier. Americans in the middle-income range today have a level of happiness that is almost identical to well-off Americans.

Most surveys of happiness simply ask people how satisfied they are with their lives. We cannot place great confidence in such studies, because this kind of overall "life satisfaction" judgment may not reflect how much people really enjoy the way they spend their time. Princeton University's Daniel Kahneman and co-researchers tried to measure people's subjective well-being by asking them about their mood at frequent intervals during a day. In an article published in Science, they report that their data confirm that there is little correlation between income and happiness. On the contrary, they found that people with higher incomes spent more time in activities that are associated with negative feelings, such as tension and stress. Instead of having more time for leisure, they spent more time at and commuting to work. They were more often in moods that they described as hostile, angry, anxious, and tense.

Of course, there is nothing new in the idea that money does not buy happiness. Many religions instruct us that attachment to material possessions makes us unhappy. The Beatles reminded us that money can't buy us love.

Even Adam Smith, who told us that it is not from the butcher's benevolence that we get our dinner, but from his regard for his self-interest, described the imagined pleasures of wealth as "a decetipn". Nevertheless, there is something paradoxical about this. Why do governments all focus on increasing per capita national income? Why do so many of us strive to obtain more money, if it won't make us happier?

7. What is the paradox between the surveys of happiness, as mentioned in the passage?

1. People may have higher incomes but spend more time having negative feelings
2. Surveys of happiness simply ask people how satisfied they are with their lives.
3. The surveys measure people's subjectivewell-being by asking them about their mood at frequent intervals
4. It is not from the butcher's benevolence that we get our dinner, but from his regard for his self interest

8. If the passage is taken from a larger article, what should come after the passage?

1. A discussion on why governments only focus on per capita incomes and their folly in doing so.
2. What are the factors, other than money, that result in happiness
3. It will prove that is not necessary to have money to be really happy
4. It will give the status of happiness in other countries of the world

PASSAGE - E

What are the possible long-run implications of promoting medical tourism, through corporate medical institutions, on the concept of public health, costs of health care and equity of the national health system? Firstly, many researchers feel it is unfair to use the term medical tourism to describe patients coming from abroad for treatment. Generally, seeking treatment for illness is associated with very high uncertainty about outcomes, tremendous stress and pain for the family and sandwiching it with a romantic phrase is nothing more than a commercial marketing tactic. Many members from the corporate community had a skeptical view about clubbing medicine and tourism. Sumanjit Chaudhry, an executive at India's Max health care group, says "I imagine if someone is sick and ill they won't want to have a holiday. You'll hardly see a guy who comes here for heart surgery leaping off and going to the beach". Further, the argument that landcorporate hospital prices are lower is a relative truth. Maybe for a foreign patient, this is true. But for a domestic patient, the cost of treatment in a five-star hospital is beyond reach, affordable only to a minority. A comparison of prices among different layers of hospitals for doing the same procedure in the cities of Chennai and Hyderabad reveals that the prices charged in corporate hospitals are three to four times higher than ordinary private hospitals. Above and beyond the arguments of comparative cost advantage, the inequities built within the rules of the international monetary system, by way of the huge differences in the nominal exchange rate value make the highest amount of difference in costs.

The huge difference between the exchange rate of domestic and foreign currency is also a major pull factor for the so-called external 'brain drain' in which the developed countries are major beneficiaries, because of their higher priced currency. The same anomaly is true within India as well with the nominal exchange rate between urban and rural areas being skewed in favour of the former. Urban-centric corporate hospitals are drawing away the best-qualified personnel from the public sector. This absorption by private corporates imposes huge costs on the public health services by deteriorating the quality of public health services.

9. Promoting medical tourism through corporate hospitals is detrimental because

1. The high charges that can be levied from foreign 'medical tourists' puts the cost of sch treatment beyond the reach of the average Indian.
2. It creates an external 'brain-drain' which benefits only developed countries.
3. Urban-centric corporate hospitals absorb the best qualified personnel from the public sector and cause deterioration in the services of the public sector

4. Seeking treatment for illness has highly unpredictable outcomes and tremendous stress and pain for the family.
5. A successful treatment is not assured.

10. The major reason for the differential in cost of medical procedures between developed and developing countries is

1. The inequities in the rules of the international monetary system by means of huge differences in the nominal exchange rate value
2. The public sector absorbs a large part of the costs incurred by corporate hospitals
3. Cost can be shared by arranging tourist attractions for attending family
4. This is part of the commercial and marketing tactics of corporate hospitals.
5. The health sector is indirectly subsidized.

Answer keys

RC Online Assignment -02		
1.	1	The government provides electricity at subsidized rates which is used excessively by farmers and leads to depletion of ground water. Hence, option 1 is the clear inferrence.
2.	2	Read the first lines of the passage.
3.	2	Read the last line of the passage.
4.	2	The other options are not budgetary measures.
5.	3	To divert attention from serious issues and hide their inability to tackle these issues , politicians shift the focus to trivial issues and it is given in the last paragraph.
6.	4	We cannot infer options 1 and 2 as there is no talk about the poor or the need fro talking. Option 3 is directly mentioned; hence only 4 can be inferred.
7.	1	The contradiction is seen only in option 1. None of the other choices gives away the paradox, even though they are mentioned in the passage
8.	2	2 Can be inferred from the last few lines. The article questions the link between money and happiness, since it debunks that link, it should explain what else is needed for happiness.
9.	3	As per the lines 'Urban-centric corporate hospitals are drawing away the best-qualified personnel from the public sector. This absorption by private corporate imposes huge costs on the public health services by deteriorating the quality of public health services, it is clear that answer is option 3.
10.	1	The option best summarizes the author's viewpoint. The exchange rate has made cost treatment prohibitive. It has made the cost of treatment out of reach of the average Indian.